METHODOLOGY FOR THE CREATION AND DEVELOPMENT OF THE ICLAC CHINESE INVESTMENT DATABASE AND INTERACTIVE MAP

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Introduction

A fundamental challenge in documenting Chinese overseas investment stems from the absence of comprehensive, transparent, enterprise-level data from official sources in the People's Republic of China. While the Ministry of Commerce (MOFCOM) publishes aggregate statistics on China's outward foreign direct investment through its annual Statistical Bulletin, these reports provide only country-level totals without identifying specific companies, projects, or investment locations within recipient nations.

This lack of granular official data—which contrasts sharply with the detailed investment registries maintained by many Western countries—creates a significant information gap for researchers, policymakers, and communities seeking to understand the actual scope and nature of Chinese economic engagement in their regions. The opacity of official Chinese investment data has necessitated reliance on secondary sources, including media reports, commercial databases, and host country records, each of which captures only partial aspects of Chinese investment activity.

This data limitation motivated the creation of the ICLAC Regional Repository of Chinese Investments in Latin America, which seeks to construct the most complete picture possible of Chinese investment in Latin America and the Caribbean by systematically triangulating information from multiple primary and secondary sources and subjecting all data to rigorous verification processes.

This methodology report details the systematic seven-step process employed to develop, verify, and publish this resource, which represents one of the most thorough documentation efforts of Chinese economic engagement with the region to date.

STEP 1: Initial Database Construction through Media Analysis (2021-2023)

The foundation of this project began with the creation of a comprehensive database documenting Chinese companies with presence in Latin American and Caribbean countries since 2001. This initial phase, funded by ANID Chile (grants 11180081 and 1230307) employed a rigorous manual analysis approach conducted between 2021 and 2023. A research team comprising five research assistants systematically examined the major newspapers in each country, acquiring subscriptions to access their complete archives.

The methodology involved searching newspaper archives using specific keywords including “China,” “investment,” “Chinese company,” “Chinese,” and “Chinese project” in the respective languages. The scope of this media analysis was extensive, covering major publications across the region. In Argentina, for instance, the team examined Clarín, La Nación, and Página 12, while in Brazil, they analyzed Folha de São Paulo, O Globo, and Estadão. Similar comprehensive coverage was achieved across all countries, from smaller Caribbean nations such as Antigua and Barbuda’s Daily Observer to larger markets including Mexico’s El Universal, Milenio, and Excelsior. Additionally, the research incorporated international financial publications including the Financial Times, New York Times, Bloomberg, Wall Street Journal, Xinhua, and South China Morning Post to capture projects that may have received limited local coverage.

Following the identification of preliminary news items, the team conducted supplementary Google searches for each identified project to gather additional information and verification. This extensive process resulted in an original database containing over 4,800 news stories about Chinese investment, sourced from more than 800 newspapers and news portals covering the period from 2001 to 2020.

Each project underwent careful categorization, distinguishing between existing operational investments and those that were announced but never materialized. The coding system included unique project identifiers, investment amounts in US dollars, ownership structure (state-owned versus private enterprises), investment motivation, announcement year, investment type (greenfield or merger and acquisition), joint ventures, projects location, and industry classification.

This initial database identified a total of 561 investment projects across 23 countries, forming the empirical foundation for Chapter 3 of the book "Economic Displacement" published by Cambridge University Press (Urdinez 2025).

STEP 2: Cross-Verification with Authoritative Sources (2022-2023)

The second phase involved meticulous verification of each news story against investment data from established authoritative sources. This triangulation process utilized both subscription-based databases, including fDi Markets and Mergr, and open-access resources such as the China Global Investment Tracker and the China Foreign Direct Investment Observatory in LAC. Each source maintained different levels of precision and focus areas. The China Global Investment Tracker, by design, excludes investments below 100 million USD, while fDi Markets specializes exclusively in greenfield FDI projects, though not exclusively deals struck by Chinese companies. Mergr focuses solely on mergers and acquisitions with limited data on Chinese enterprises, and the China Foreign Direct Investment Observatory in LAC, directed by economist Enrique Dussel Peters, showed significant overlap with fDi Markets data while also incorporating construction projects wherein China retains no ownership.

Where available, the team incorporated reliable national sources to enhance verification. In Chile, for example, InvestChile, a government entity responsible for registering investment projects and attracting foreign investment, provided valuable information about Chinese projects in the country. Similarly, in Brazil, the Brazil-China Business Council and the BRICS Policy Center think tank offered detailed information about Chinese investments in Brazil.

Our project follows the OECD's definition of FDI. At its core, the OECD considers FDI to exist when an investor resident in one country establishes a lasting interest in an enterprise operating in another country. Notably, not all international investment qualifies as FDI. The OECD establishes a crucial threshold: the investor must own at least 10% of the voting power in the foreign enterprise. This percentage isn't arbitrary - it reflects the idea that with 10% or more, the investor has sufficient influence to participate effectively in the management of the company (OECD 2008).

To facilitate the identification of Chinese ownership, we created three ownership levels, namely: full acquisition (100%), majority acquisition (50% - 99%), and minority acquisition (<49%).

During this phase, it became necessary to distinguish a new category of projects that do not qualify as foreign direct investment, namely public works contracts where Chinese companies execute infrastructure projects such as bridges and dams. Many of these projects, which received substantial media coverage, were documented in the AidData China database managed by William & Mary University. Although these projects do not fit the OECD definition of FDI, we decided to retain these projects and identify them as "construction" since they represent a considerable portion of Chinese activity in Latin America and the Caribbean. The repository's construction projects are those wherein Chinese companies have developing projects and being paid for this work, but do not retain ownership of the infrastructure they build, which belongs to the state or a private contractor. We remove construction project values from our counts of total Chinese operational FDI in the region.

In this phase, investment project sectors were standardized into seven categories plus the aforementioned infrastructure projects. These are: energy, manufacturing, real estate, mining, ICT, agribusiness, and finance. Assigning projects to one of these sectors can be challenging, since there are cases that could belong to two sectors. For example, a soy pellet factory could belong to either agribusiness or manufacturing. China's limited forestry investments in the region do not fall neatly into any of these categories, so have been classified as manufacturing given the end use of the lumber in question. Furthermore, within the same category there can be very different projects - for example, the energy category features both solar park and oil drilling projects.

The criterion for defining the investment year was the commencement of construction work, or alternatively, the year when the acquisition operation was completed. In other words, we carefully accounted for the time lag that can exist between the initial announcement and the project's completion. We also considered that many projects are announced but never completed. If a company acquires a project and years later reinvests to expand or improve that project, these are counted as two separate investments and indicated as "second investment" or "second reinvestment" in the repository. If Chinese investment eventually ends because investors sell their assets to another company, this project is classified as terminated and removed from the map. We maintain a separate database of projects that were announced but never completed, and of projects that were completed but left the market years later. This database, described in the previous edition of this report as yet to be published, was formalized during the 2025-2026 update and is described in detail in section 7.4.

This verification stage resulted in the elimination of projects that could not be confirmed by additional sources and lacked either a verified postal address or an official website confirming the investment's implementation. When discrepancies arose between the collected data and these authoritative sources, the team carefully reviewed and corrected investment attributes such as amounts and announcement years.

This phase was conducted with support from a six-person team affiliated with the Núcleo Milenio project on China's Impacts in Latin America and the Caribbean, funded by ANID Chile. Here, each project underwent a multi-stage and multilingual review process during which several adjunct researchers and research assistants from across the region and Asia sequentially scrutinized the dataset: once one researcher completed their verification, the project entry was passed on to another for cross-checking. This serial procedure ensured maximum attention to detail, comprehensive triangulation across multiple sources, and the consistency of coding decisions.

This database was used in chapters 1 and 2 of Urdinez's book (2025). To provide context for the comprehensiveness and reliability of our methodology, we conducted a systematic comparison of our findings with other major databases tracking Chinese investment in Latin America and the Caribbean for the period 2001-2020.

Our methodology at this stage identified a total Chinese investment stock of US$265.59 billion across the region during this twenty-year period. This figure represents substantially more investment activity than what was captured by other leading databases. The combined data from fDi Markets and Mergr, two prominent commercial investment tracking services, recorded only US$140.2 billion in Chinese investment for the same period—approximately 53% of what our comprehensive methodology uncovered. This significant difference can be attributed to our inclusion of smaller-scale investments that fall below the reporting thresholds of commercial databases, as well as our systematic capture of projects that received primarily local media coverage rather than international financial press attention.

The China Global Investment Tracker, maintained by the American Enterprise Institute and Heritage Foundation (Scissors 2021), documented US$190.01 billion in Chinese investment stock. While this represents a more complete picture than the commercial databases, it still accounts for only 71% of the investments we identified. This gap is primarily explained by the China Global Investment Tracker's deliberate exclusion of all investments below US$100 million, which our research shows constitute a significant portion of Chinese economic engagement in the region, particularly in manufacturing and agribusiness sectors.

Perhaps most surprisingly, our database captured less than half of the investment reported in the Statistical Bulletin of the People's Republic of China, which claimed US$629.81 billion in Chinese investment stock in Latin America and the Caribbean. This substantial discrepancy of more than US$364 billion raises important questions about methodology and definitions. The official Chinese statistics appear to include financial flows and transactions that do not meet the OECD definition of foreign direct investment, such as short-term loans, portfolio investments, or financial instruments that do not establish lasting management interest in local enterprises.

STEP 3: Case Study Identification and Knowledge Gap Analysis (2023-2025)

In partnership with the Inter-American Dialogue, under the leadership of Margaret Myers, the team initiated a systematic search for case studies corresponding to each investment project, aiming to identify knowledge gaps regarding Chinese projects. A qualifying case study was defined as a document in English, Portuguese, Spanish, or Chinese that analyzed a specific investment, contained at least one page of qualitative content about the investment, was published by an academic affiliated with an academic institution, and resulted from academic research.

This phase proceeded in stages, beginning with Chile, Peru, and Argentina in late 2023, followed by Bolivia, Ecuador, Uruguay, Brazil, and Paraguay in early 2024. In 2025, the process expanded to include Colombia, Venezuela, Guyana, Suriname, and Panama. This systematic approach to identifying existing scholarship revealed significant gaps in academic documentation of Chinese investments across the region.

Of the first eight countries published by ICLAC, out of the 363 investment and construction projects represented in our database, only 113 (31 percent) included case studies.

STEP 4: Local Expert Validation (2023-2024)

Following the case study identification phase, the advanced database underwent verification by local partners with expertise in Chinese investment. In Chile, where the project is based, researchers affiliated with ICLAC from Universidad de Chile and Pontificia Universidad Católica de Chile reviewed the database, with additional consultations conducted with the Chile-China Chamber of Commerce. Data on Argentina was reviewed by experts at the China-Argentina Center at the University of Buenos Aires and officials from the Argentina-China Chamber of Commerce. In Peru, experts from the Center for Studies on China and Asia-Pacific (CECHAP) at Universidad del Pacífico conducted the review.

For Brazil, an independent consultant specializing in Chinese investment reviewed the database. In Uruguay, an academic from ORT University provided verification, while in Colombia, the review involved an academic from Universidad del Rosario and members of the Colombia-China Chamber of Commerce. At this stage, the ICLAC database often proved more comprehensive and accurate than the databases maintained by local partners themselves, though the process served to identify new projects requiring addition and to verify investment amounts and project details where uncertainties remained. These regional institutions are critical partners in this project and will continue to work alongside the ICLAC team to verify and update data. These "on-the-ground" partnerships and our collaborative approach importantly distinguish the repository from other efforts to track Chinese investment in the region.

STEP 5: Georeferencing and Spatial Documentation (2024)

With the database from steps three and four completed for eight countries, the project advanced to the georeferencing phase. ICLAC's efforts to georeference instances of operational Chinese investment in the region are intended to convey the geographical ambit of these deals, as well as the extent to which some projects may be interoperable, including across borders. These efforts distinguish the repository from other FDI tracking projects.

The projects in the database were first differentiated between those requiring point mapping (such as factories or offices) and those requiring vector mapping (such as electrical networks, roads, rail, or gas pipelines). Throughout 2024, a team of geographers specializing in GIS systems conducted this work.

To confirm exact project locations, the team consulted official company websites, government documentation, and ministry of public works records for infrastructure projects. For example, Joyvio's salmon farms in southern Chile were identified through company reports filed with the Ministry of Environment. By this verification level, nearly all projects possessed some form of public registration, such as a tax identification number. Each investment was assigned specific coordinates, and for projects conveyed as vectors, coordinates along the project's path were identified and then displayed on the repository's map.

STEP 6: Publication and Interactive Platform Development

The final process involved generation and publication of the interactive map and related functions on the website. These functionalities were developed by the Millennium Institute for Foundational Research on Data (IMFD), which, with input from ICLAC leadership and affiliates, transformed the raw data into an interactive tool and incorporated English, Spanish, and Chinese versions of the web interface. In collaboration with IMFD, the data continues to undergo biannual updates.

The platform is intended to be interactive and includes a contact mechanism allowing users to report errors or provide feedback, ensuring continuous improvement and accuracy of the database. To ensure maximum transparency and also access to and use of the data, raw data is fully available for public download. From this study, a report was published in English and in Chinese (Urdinez & Myers 2025).

IA STEP 7: AI-Assisted Verification and Reliability Scores (2025-2026)

Between 2025 and 2026 the repository expanded from the eight countries originally published to twenty-two. Central America and the Caribbean were incorporated —Costa Rica, Nicaragua, Honduras, Guatemala, El Salvador, Trinidad and Tobago, Cuba, Jamaica, and the Dominican Republic— and, in parallel, the countries already published were subjected to a systematic sweep of investments announced or completed in 2025 and 2026. This growth brought the repository to 741 recorded investments and exceeded the capacity of the serial procedure described in Step 2, in which each entry passed sequentially through several researchers. The seventh step introduces, in response, a layer of verification assisted by language models, an explicit and publishable indicator of the strength of the evidence supporting each record, and a documented annex of the projects that remain outside the map.

7.1. Language models as a supporting tool

The team incorporated Claude, the language model developed by Anthropic, as a supporting tool in three narrowly defined functions. The first is the systematic country-by-country sweep of regional press, corporate registries, and the reference databases already cited in Step 2, in order to propose investments missing from the repository. The second is the cross-check of the existing database against new sources, to detect amounts, start years, or ownership structures that had become outdated. The third is the detection of internal inconsistencies in the dataset: order-of-magnitude errors in amounts, duplicate records, misattributed companies, coordinates that do not correspond to the stated province, and violations of the schema contract.

One rule governs the entire procedure: the model proposes, it never confirms. No output from the assistant enters the repository without a human researcher verifying it against the primary source. The model is not a source and is not cited as one; its findings are working hypotheses that must be sustained by government documentation, company communications, or reference press.

This caution is not an abstract precaution. During the development of the project, an agent built locally by the team generated sources that did not exist and investments that did not correspond to real transactions. That experience motivated the design of the current procedure and the explicit decision not to delegate the confirmation of any datum to the model. The assistant broadens coverage and accelerates error detection; it does not replace the documentary verification described in Steps 2 and 4.

7.2. The reliability score

The second contribution of this stage is the reliability score, an ordinal index from 0 to 5 that quantifies the strength of the documentary evidence supporting each investment. In operational terms, the score equals the number of reliable, independent sources supporting the entry, plus one.

Score	Meaning	Independent sources
5	Four or more primary sources: government documentation, official registry or filing, the company's own communication, or international reference press (Reuters, Bloomberg, Financial Times).	4 or more
4	Three reliable sources, independent of one another.	3
3	Two reliable sources.	2
2	A single reliable source; project details are plausible but uncorroborated.	1
1	Only a secondary mention; the amount or the type of transaction is uncertain.	Partial
0	Doubtful: implausible amount, no documentary evidence, or possible duplicate of another record.	None

Independence between sources is the condition that makes the score informative. Two outlets reproducing the same wire dispatch count as a single source, and the same applies when several entries of one investment programme rest on the same documentary record: in that case the evidence supports the programme as a whole and not each phase separately. Each entry records in the reliability_notes field the justification for its score in free text, indicating which sources were considered independent and which aspects of the record remain uncorroborated. At the close of this stage, 609 of the 741 investments carry that documented justification.

7.3. Publication threshold

The ICLAC methodology requires more than three reliable sources for the definitive inclusion of an investment. Strictly speaking, only a score of 5 meets that threshold; a score of 4, with three sources, is considered to be at the limit of acceptance. Investments with a score of 2 or below are not published on the interactive map.

Score	Investments	Share	Destination
5	266	35.9%	Published on the map
4	219	29.6%	Published on the map
3	150	20.2%	Published on the map
2	49	6.6%	Annex of excluded projects
1	26	3.5%	Annex of excluded projects
0	7	0.9%	Annex of excluded projects
Not yet scored	24	3.2%	Pending external review
Total	741	100.0%	

Of the 741 investments recorded at the close of this stage, 82 were left with a score of 2 or below, and none of them appears on the published map. The score is assigned by a reviewer who did not take part in collecting the entry. This separation of duties prevents whoever gathered the evidence from judging its own sufficiency, and is the reason why the investments incorporated at the close of the 2026 round deliberately entered without a score, pending that independent review.

7.4. The annex of projects excluded from the map

From its inception the repository has distinguished between investments that are published and those that, for various reasons, should not appear on the map. In earlier editions that distinction was applied, but the excluded set was kept as a separate, unpublished database. During this stage the annex was formalized: each excluded record retains all of its fields, including its sources and its score, and additionally carries a field recording the reason for exclusion. The annex gathers 106 investments across 20 countries, between 2003 and 2026, for a total of US$72,221 million.

Reason for exclusion	Investments	Share
Insufficient evidence (score of 2 or below)	69	65.1%
Cancelled or suspended project	25	23.6%
Announcement, memorandum or study never executed	6	5.7%
Duplicate of another record	5	4.7%
Not an investment	1	0.9%
Total	106	100.0%

The categories correspond to different situations and should not be conflated. Records of insufficient evidence are projects that probably exist but whose documentation does not meet the threshold: they remain in the annex pending additional sources, and may re-enter the map if those appear. Cancelled or suspended projects, by contrast, are investments that were announced and never carried out, or that stopped after beginning. Duplicates are already-resolved recording errors, kept on file to leave a record of the decision. Announcements, memoranda of understanding, and feasibility studies without execution correspond to declared commitments that never materialized in works or in an acquisition.

Maintaining this annex serves three purposes. The first is traceability: an investment that was once on the map and no longer is has a recorded, verifiable reason, rather than disappearing without explanation. The second is research: the set of projects announced and never completed is itself a relevant object of study for understanding the gap between the announcement and the execution of Chinese investment in the region. The third is quality control: by preserving the reason for each exclusion, the team can review its own decisions and correct them when new evidence emerges. The investment figures the project reports correspond exclusively to the investments published on the map; the amounts in the annex are not added to any aggregate.

7.5. Results of the verification layer

The systematic review of the existing database, carried out with the support of the assistant and confirmed documentarily by the team, identified three families of errors that had survived the earlier stages.

The first are order-of-magnitude errors in amounts, generally by factors of ten, one hundred, or one thousand. The water treatment plants built by PowerChina in Guyana were recorded at US$3,977 million when the complete project cost around US$30 million; Zijin's acquisition of Rosebel Gold Mines in Suriname was recorded at US$3,600 million when the transaction was US$360 million. Correcting five entries reduced the recorded stock for Guyana from US$9,900 million to US$2,604 million.

The second are duplicate records, almost always originating in the double counting of the announcement and the closing of one and the same transaction. Three Peruvian transactions —CNPC and Petrobras Energía Perú, China Three Gorges and Hydro Global, and China Southern Power Grid and Enel Distribución Perú— appeared twice, with US$5,858 million counted twice. The rule in Step 2, which fixes the year of the investment at the closing of the acquisition, made it possible to resolve which of the two entries to retain.

The third are misattributions, both of company and of the nature of the asset: works credited to a company other than the one that executed them, and projects described with a technology that did not correspond. To these are added geographic inconsistencies, such as coordinates assigned to a province that was not their own, which the georeferencing of Step 5 had not detected because the errors lay in the text field and not in the coordinates.

7.6. Project coordination and data architecture

The execution of this stage rested on two functions that merit explicit mention, because they sustain the work of the entire research team and are seldom recorded in the description of a methodology.

Florencia Muñoz, as project manager of the repository, coordinated the team of research assistants distributed across Chile, Argentina, Peru, Colombia, and the United States; organised the sequence of country deliveries, integrated the partial contributions of each national team, and maintained the consistency of the database across successive rounds of updating. The expansion to fourteen new countries and the 2025-2026 sweep were possible thanks to that coordination.

Felipe Soto, in charge of design and data analysis, developed the architecture underpinning the interactive map, defined the schema contract that standardises the national databases —field types, controlled vocabularies for sector and project type, identifier and coordinate formats— and ran the validations preceding each publication. That contract is what allows databases built by different teams, in different countries, and at different moments, to be integrated without loss of information.

Conclusion

This seven-step methodology represents a comprehensive approach to documenting Chinese investment in Latin America and the Caribbean, combining extensive media analysis, multiple verification layers, academic validation, and sophisticated spatial documentation. The resulting database and interactive map provide researchers, policymakers, and stakeholders with an unprecedented resource for understanding the scope, distribution, and characteristics of Chinese economic engagement in the region. The iterative nature of the methodology, with its multiple validation stages, including with repository partner organizations, and ongoing updates, ensures both accuracy and relevance as Chinese investment patterns continue to evolve across Latin America and the Caribbean.

The incorporation of an AI-assisted verification layer, of a publishable reliability score, and of a documented annex of excluded projects, described in Step 7, responds to the scale the repository has reached and to the need for users to be able to judge for themselves the strength of the evidence behind each record. None of the three replaces the documentary verification work that has defined the project since its inception: the first amplifies it, the second makes it explicit, and the third preserves what publication leaves out.

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